

Eventbrite

How to Win Sponsors for Your Event (And Bring Them Back Every Year)



Sponsorship can mean the difference between turning a profit — or a financial disaster.

Imagine each year you find yourself wasting time (and money) cultivating last minute opportunities and building new relationships all because you didn't put in effort earlier to create a true partnership with your sponsors...leading to them inevitably dropping you.

Or, you've secured sponsors but you don't deliver on your promises. You tarnish your relationship with those brands and it leaves you blacklisted among other possible sponsors.

Or, you didn't even win over the sponsors you needed, so you're left footing the bill for items your sponsors would have covered. You're then forced to cut corners because your budget is tight. Attendees (and the press) condemn you on social media.

In our annual Pulse Report survey, 31% of respondents said that sponsorship was their top secondary revenue channel. And whether you're doing it yourself, have a whole team dedicated to sponsors, or plan to outsource your sponsorship program to an agency, sponsorships are a full-time job.

For more advanced information about how to get into the heads of sponsors — and create relationships that are long lasting and mutually beneficial — keep reading.

This guide is for festival and event directors who:

- Know why sponsorship is important — both for their brand and their budget
- Want to avoid spending time and money trying to acquire the wrong sponsors
- Need help preserving relationships with their event's current sponsors

You'll learn how to:

- Better assess sponsors to ensure they're a good fit for your event
- Effectively prove your value proposition
- Retain your most valuable sponsors, instead of starting from scratch with every event

Meet the experts



Adi Anand

Director of Business Development,
Sound on Sound Fest



John Riccardi

Strategic Account Manager,
Music at Eventbrite



Angela Terry

Director of Operations,
California Capital Airshow



Larry Weil

President of The
Sponsorship Guy™



Kristi Yim

Founder and Owner,
Resonate



Abby Clemence

Co-Founder and Managing Director,
of Infinity Sponsorship

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Brand partnerships could be the difference between building a sustainable business or dipping ticket sales.

In a saturated market, events are looking for new ways to stand out. The right sponsors can be a major draw for your attendees, and can actually be the deciding factor for attendees on whether they click “Buy” — or if they pass you by. That means in the near future, brand partnerships could be the difference between building a sustainable business or dipping ticket sales.

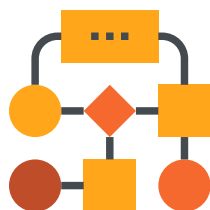
However, some brands might already be in multi-year contracts or some brands might be more interested in your competitor (or already sponsoring them). Other brands might not be the right fit for your audience.

So, how to do you find the right sponsors for your brand? First things first: Do your homework.

Steps to finding your sponsors

Follow these three key steps to finding those sponsors.

- **Identify broad categories of brands to approach.** You've looked through your attendee data and checked out Facebook Insights to get to [know your attendees](#) — their key behaviours, interests, and spending habits. What type of companies do they like, generally? For example, if the majority of your attendees are interested in craft beer, you should include craft beer companies as potential sponsors. If your attendees are interested in luxury travel, then spas and resorts should be on the table. Or if you're hosting a small art show, local art galleries and art suppliers are going to be good options.





- **Identify specific brands.** Now that you've identified what type of company you want, it's time to make a list of potential sponsors and research them. You want to learn everything you can about those brands, including their sponsorship process. Set up Google alerts, look through the company's website, press coverage, and social media accounts. Do they even sponsor events? Are their sponsorship requirements on their website? Are there people who specifically work on sponsorships, or will you be working with someone in their marketing department?



- **Narrow down your list.** Use your research to narrow down your list. Be critical: The brand might be popular, but if your research revealed they're not a good fit, don't bother reaching out to them. Focus your attention on the potential sponsors that fit with your audience. If the attendees at your small art show favour local, organic food, you'd be better off choosing a local grocery store known for fresh ingredients over a big-name, fast food restaurant.

“ Do research to find out which companies would resonate with your audience. Work together so the brand has meaningful and engaging connections with the event audience which will result in a longer-term partnership and, ultimately, open the door to lead the brand to other opportunities that you represent.

Kristi Yim, Founder and Owner of Resonate



Whether you're a pop-up wedding fair or a multi-day auto show, the key to winning the right sponsors is proving your value.

"If there's one thing I would underscore, it's that every sponsorship should be approached as a collaboration, a partnership based on customised goals and execution."

John Riccardi, Strategic Account Manager at Eventbrite

Now on the music team at Eventbrite, Riccardi previously managed sponsorships for various large-scale promoters and festivals.

Want your sponsors to see you as a true partner? Here's how.

Start with the basics



- **Define your audience:** When you're pitching a potential sponsor, start with the basics. Are you giving potential sponsors access to a local audience? National? Global? How many attendees do you have each year? How much money do they spend at your event? Brands are buying audiences, not assets.
- **Be clear about your objectives:** What are you looking for from your sponsors? Funding only? Exposure to their audiences/stakeholders? A multi-event contract?



- **Prove your ROI.** Talk about the “what’s in it for them.” Your sponsors want to know the return on investment (ROI) - i.e. that they’re going to get back more than they spend. To truly win over sponsors, create your value proposition around their key performance indicators (KPIs) and prove you’re indispensable to them. Your sponsors expect you to bring ideas to the table and then tailor your pitch to meet their specific need/s.

Creating Your Value Proposition

Every sponsor has different KPIs, like the number of event attendees, the number of new social media followers, or the number of email signups. And every sponsor has different goals — to expand brand awareness, to access your attendee database, or maybe just to sell more. It’s your job to convince sponsors you can help them achieve those goals better than any other festival or event.

“Most brands and companies know the market, demographic, and audience they want to target. Festivals have a captive audience they can offer brands.”

Adi Anand, Director of Business Development for Sound on Sound Fest

Use your [pitch deck](#) to show the full value of sponsoring your event. By the end of your presentation, your sponsors should know that you have a clear understanding of their goals — and that you’re going to help them achieve those goals.

Many companies doing sponsorships may entertain your proposal if they see a fit with their objectives.

Need help? Here are six questions to shape your value proposition. Make sure the answers to these questions are in your pitch — and in your follow-up emails:

- What are your sponsor's key objectives?
- What do they need to be successful?
- How will sponsoring your event benefit this company?
- How does your event tie to their brand?
- How does your event tie to their marketing objectives?
- Why are you targeting this company as opposed to other similar companies?

Remember that many companies doing sponsorships have a limited budget, well-defined objectives, and are not eager to spend with another event. They're not searching for new sponsorship opportunities – but may entertain your proposal if they see a fit with their objectives.



Sponsors talk — so if you damage one relationship, you'll damage them all.

Here are four mistakes to avoid to make sure you don't become a sponsorship pariah. Share this list with anyone on your team who interacts with sponsors.



Mistake #1: Information overload.

Sponsors are overwhelmed with information — they get lots of emails every day, are on conference calls, and are in and out of meetings from morning to evening. Sending a proposal with too much information, especially during the first email or call, is a no-no. While it might seem efficient, you'll end up disengaging sponsors before you even have a chance to get in the door.



Mistake #2: Ignoring the finer details

Every pitch deck, call, or engagement is an opportunity to get it right and/or do it wrong. Create a checklist to go over before you send something to a sponsor — everything from spelling the brand's name correctly to tailoring the communication for that person.



Mistake #3: Confusing activity for progress.

"One of the biggest mistakes event creators can make is just sending a proposal and thinking all the work is done," says Larry Weil, President of The Sponsorship Guy™. "One event that wanted my company to sponsor them sent two boxes completely full of information and no context — other than the proposal. Sponsors won't even look at that material, so it's all a waste."



Mistake #4: Not getting total buy-in.

"Sponsorship decisions aren't made in isolation," warns Abby Clemence, Co-Founder and Managing Director, of Infinity Sponsorship. "Decision makers will want to get buy-in from other areas of the business. And if you've done your due diligence and asked every contact or connection the right questions, you'll have qualified the opportunity for them."

How to be the perfect partner for your sponsor

Do you have the qualities of a perfect partner for your sponsor? These are the three qualities sponsors are looking for in a partner.

- **Authentic:** Sponsors are looking for partners — not gold diggers. To keep sponsors coming back each year, you need to clearly show that you're interested in the sponsors' success. Don't just call at renewal time — check in monthly or quarterly and give updates about the event.
- **Flexible:** Your sponsors are businesses too, and their objectives and team might change throughout the course of your event. If necessary, you might need to adjust your strategy to achieve your sponsor's goals.
- **Dedicated:** From initial outreach to onsite to post-event follow-up, your team should have a dedicated liaison to address any of your sponsor's needs. That person will make sure sponsors know where to load in, where to pick up credentials, and when to expect a post-event fulfillment report.



Proving your ROI — and getting sponsors to re-sign

While your team surely has the best of intentions, if they can't deliver on what they promise, sponsors will walk out the door. In fact, proving your value is the foundation of a long-term relationship.

In your initial meeting, you learned what KPIs were most important to your sponsor. Now it's time to collect the data. Here are three easy ways to get data that will matter to your sponsor.

- **Surveys.** Integrate questions about your sponsors (and their presence at your event) into your post-event survey. That direct feedback from attendees to sponsors provides insights that show sponsors the value of your event.
- **Social media.** Social media is your ally when it comes to proving the ROI of sponsorships. You can provide sponsors with information such as how many users interact with sponsor messaging on your social feeds, how many new followers came directly after mentioning a sponsor in a post, and how many times you mentioned a sponsor in social posts.
- **RFID.** If your event is equipped with [radio-frequency identification \(RFID\)](#) technology, you can find out things like how many people interacted with a sponsor's station. And better? Instead of having fans manually enter their information on an iPad, sponsors can collect that data with the swipe of a wristband or badge.

Once you have that data, put it all together and send a fulfillment report to your sponsors. "Your fulfillment report is an extension of your proposal, proving that you actually delivered," says Weil. "It should include a list of the deliverables you promised and proof (usually photos). That report should also include actual attendance, news coverage, social traction, and ads promoting your event."

Now That You're "Sponsor Ready"

Sometimes, finding the right sponsors for your event can seem like a fruitless effort. And keeping your sponsors year after year can feel nearly impossible.

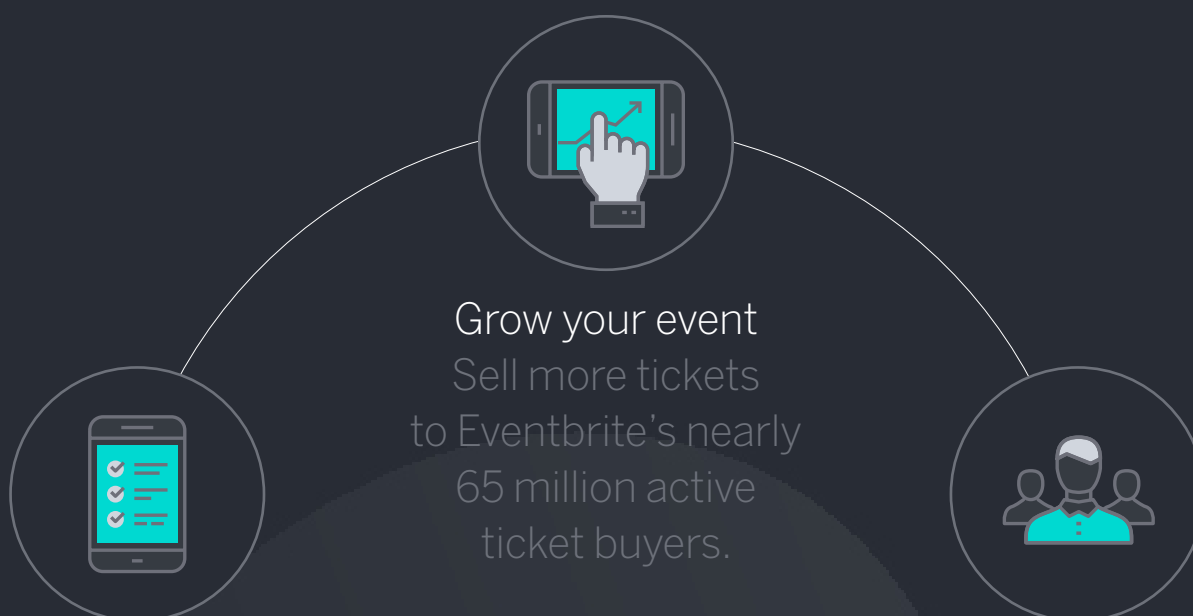
However, with the right strategy, identifying new opportunities and developing those relationships becomes second nature. Save time, money, and stress by focusing on securing partnerships - not transactions.

To learn how you can be your sponsor's favourite event, contact us [here](#) or give us a call on 0800 652 4993.

Eventbrite

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